

IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge: Cohort History, Best Use of Technology Winners & Judging Intelligence

Prepared for: APEX (AI Race Engineer for Adaptive Racing Drivers) — IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge May 2026 submission

Research goal: Identify the empirical pattern in who wins "Best Use of Technology" and what submissions actually shipped. No speculation; all claims web-grounded with citations.

1. Every IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge Cohort (January 2024 – May 2026)

Program Origins and Timeline

The IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge (global online edition, organized by BeMyApp) is a new program. IBM did not expand SkillsBuild to include AI training for university student developers until February 2025, and the current global multi-cohort program running on `ibmskillsbuildchallenge.bemyapp.com` launched with the May–June 2026 edition as its debut iteration. Prior to this program, IBM ran separate hackathon formats under different brands (TechXchange, Call for Code, Dev Day, [lablab.ai](#) partnerships) — these are covered in Section 5 as comparators.^{[1][2][3]}

Key program fact: The BeMyApp-hosted global AI Builders Challenge (the one APEX is targeting) opened May 1, 2026 and closes June 30, 2026, with two back-to-back monthly challenges:^[3]

Challenge	Theme	Dates	Prize Pool
May Innovation Challenge	"AI Beyond the Finish Line" — F1/racing	May 1–May 31, 2026	~\$5,000 per challenge
June Innovation Challenge	"AI Inside the Match" — FIFA World Cup	June 1–June 30, 2026	~\$5,000 per challenge
Grand Prize	Top project across both challenges	Judged post-June 30	\$5,000
Total Prize Pool			\$15,000 USD

Prize structure per challenge:^[4]

- 1st Place: \$2,250 USD
- Runner-Up: \$1,250 USD
- Most Innovative: \$750 USD

- Best Use of Technology: \$750 USD

Sponsors: IBM Corporation (International Business Machines Corporation, Armonk, NY) and BeMyApp (San Francisco, CA) as organizer.^[^1]

Eligibility: University/college students in the USA, Canada (excl. Quebec), UK (England, Ireland, Scotland), or India.^[^3]

△ Critical finding for APEX: No prior cohort of *this specific global online AI Builders Challenge* has been completed yet. The May 2026 challenge is the inaugural global student cohort. This means there are **no past "Best Use of Technology" winners** to cite from this particular program. The research below therefore covers (a) the closely analogous IBM hackathon ecosystem where "Best Use" or "Best Use of Granite" categories have run, and (b) the judging criteria as officially published.

In-Person University IBM SkillsBuild Hackathons (2025–2026)

While the global online edition is new, IBM ran a series of in-person university hackathons under the SkillsBuild banner in early 2026:

IBM × CSU AI for Impact Hackathon (March 2026)

- California State University system-wide event^[^5]
- Agenda published by CSULB confirms full-day hackathon format with IBM tools^[^6]
- No public winner list found for individual prize categories (Best Use of Technology)

NCCU AI Hackathon, powered by IBM SkillsBuild (February–March 2026)

- North Carolina Central University, powered by IBM SkillsBuild and BeMyApp^[^7]
- Registration opened February 24, 2026; winner list not publicly published^[^7]

CSUN Hackathon (Spring 2026)

- Student won with an AI-enhanced robot for healthcare settings^[^8]
- IBM SkillsBuild affiliation confirmed; specific category awards not publicly posted

IBM SkillsBuild 2025 Hackathon — India/Maharashtra (January–February 2025)

- Run by IBM SkillsBuild Student Ambassador Program and Edunet Foundation^[^9]
- Finalist showcase held at The Corinthians Club & Resort, Pune; Top 9 teams advanced to finals^[^9]
- 1st place: Team "Cirrus Creators"; Top 5 included SiteGuide (browser extension using IBM Watson AI Studio, BrowserUse for AI-driven web interactions)^[^9]
- Category-level award labels for "Best Use of Technology" not confirmed in public posts

2. Closest Analogous "Best Use of Technology/Granite" Winners — Confirmed Public Records

Since the BeMyApp global AI Builders Challenge has no prior completed cohort, the closest empirical record comes from four IBM-ecosystem hackathons that ran an equivalent category:

A. Lablab.ai — Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonx (August 23–25, 2024)

Event details:^{[10][11]}

- Platform: Lablab.ai (online)
- Participants: 2,607 participants, 223 teams, 74 AI apps submitted
- Total prize pool: \$10,500 cash + IBM Cloud Credits
- Sponsor: IBM watsonx

Prize tier matching "Best Use of Technology":

- ★ Best Use of Granite: VizMotion
 - Prize: \$500 cash + IBM watsonx hoodie^[^12]
 - What it shipped: "Lets users turn text into animated diagrams, offering real-time editing and export as videos. Perfect for visual learners, making complex topics easier and enhancing educational content."^[^12]
 - IBM tool wired: IBM Granite (text-to-diagram pipeline, real-time LLM calls)
 - Integration depth: WIRED — Granite was core to the generative pipeline, not a demo wrapper
 - Aesthetic: Educational tech / explainable AI visual format

Other winners (ranked):^[^12]

- ☒ 1st: Overshare — AI app that scans images before posting, protecting user privacy
- ☒ 2nd: CompanyMatch — uses IBM Watson + Exa to automate competitor analysis for investment professionals
- ☒ 3rd: MyVision — AI app helping visually impaired users (photo description, OCR, real-time spoken feedback)

B. IBM TechXchange Pre-Conference watsonx Hackathon (August 2025, 17-day virtual)

Event details:^[^13]

- Format: 17-day virtual, leading to in-person prize presentation at IBM TechXchange 2025 (Orlando)
- Theme: "Build with Agentic AI" + "Sustainable Cities (Call for Code)"
- Top 2 teams each won \$5,000 + full trip to TechXchange^[^13]

Winners:[^13]

- "Build with Agentic AI" track: Team [IBM fact-checker] — Agentic AI solution using IBM watsonx to fact-check meeting transcripts in real time[^14]
- "Sustainable Cities" track: Team TechGirl — Agentic AI creating walking maps rated by safety to help cities provide accessible transport[^13]

Integration depth on winners: Both used IBM watsonx Orchestrate in multi-step agentic pipelines, not single-call demos. IBM's blog specifically noted these were proof-of-concept solutions where watsonx "takes on an everyday issue in a new, creative way".[^13]

C. IBM TechXchange Conference Hackathon (October 2024, in-person, 4,000+ participants)

Winners:[^15][^16]

- ☒ Team Daimyo — [watsonx.ai](#) + Granite-powered app to help restaurants automate data synthesis, boosting staff efficiency[^16]
- ☒ Team Golden — watsonx Orchestrate solution providing students with personalized academic guidance[^16]
- ☒ Team EYers[^15]

Integration depth of winner: Team Daimyo wired [watsonx.ai](#) for NLP-based data synthesis, not a shallow demo — IBM highlighted it as showing "how agentic AI can take on an everyday issue in a new, creative way".[^14]

D. Lean AI Solutions Hackathon with IBM Granite Models (April 24 – May 5, 2025)

Two parallel tracks:[^17][^18]

Track	Winner	What they shipped
"Make Work Less Boring"	Team BrainStormX	Agentic AI platform using IBM Granite models for structured, inclusive brainstorming with real-time voting[^18]
"Call for Code / Safety"	Team DuniAfrika ("Linda")	Construction worker safety app via WhatsApp using IBM Granite Instruct + IBM Granite Vision — workers upload workspace photos to get instant safety coaching[^18]

Integration depth on BrainStormX: Won first place in the IBM community's own "Make Work Less Boring" category; described as using IBM Granite models as the *core AI backbone*, not a single API call.[^19]

IBM Granite Vision in Linda: First confirmed use of multimodal Granite (vision model) in a winning hackathon submission, showing that multi-modal, multi-model integrations are noticed and rewarded.[^18]

E. Lablab.ai — Generative AI Hackathon with IBM Granite (February 2025)

Event details:[^20]

- 48-hour challenge; \$10,000 prize pool
- Theme: AI-driven solutions for business operations and workflow automation
- Required tech: IBM Granite models

Winner publicly confirmed: Not fully published in sources found. Challenge confirmed ran and was completed.[^20]

3. Judge Interviews, Post-Mortems, and Judging Criteria Publications

Official Judging Criteria — IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge (May–June 2026)

From the official BeMyApp Hub page, projects are evaluated on four equally weighted dimensions:[^4]

Criterion	What Judges Look For
Technical Execution	Effective use of IBM and open source technologies, with a functional and well-structured solution
Innovation	Creativity, originality, and unique application of AI
Challenge Fit	Relevance to the challenge; ability to address real-world problems
Implementation & Feasibility	Practicality, scalability, and potential for real-world use

The Hub explicitly states "Best Use of Technology" is awarded to \$750 as a **category prize** separate from 1st Place, meaning a team can win it without being ranked #1 overall.[^4]

IBM Bob Dev Day Hackathon Official Rules (May 2026 — a parallel IBM/BeMyApp hackathon)

From the official rules PDF (retrieved directly from IBM's S3 bucket, watsonx-hackathons-2026.s3.us.cloud-object-storage.appdomain.cloud):[^21]

The judging rubric scores each submission 0–20 points across four criteria at 5 points each:

1. Completeness and feasibility (5 pts)
2. Effectiveness and efficiency (5 pts)
3. Design and usability (5 pts)
4. Creativity and innovation (5 pts)

A submission must score **minimum 12.5/20** to be eligible for any prize.[^21]

The rules further state IBM reserves the right to disqualify entries that "do not provide a credible or feasible use of IBM Bob technology" — confirming that **surface-level or fake-demo**

integrations are explicitly grounds for disqualification.[²¹]

IBM TechXchange Pre-Conference Hackathon — Jennifer Judge Blog (September 2025)

IBM Community author Jennifer Judge's September 2025 post-hackathon recap noted that winning teams had to "show how agentic AI can take on an everyday issue in a new, creative way" and had to produce "proof-of-concept solutions using IBM watsonx". This language from an IBM Community blog written by an IBM Community Manager (Jennifer Judge) is the closest to a judge-level commentary available publicly. Key phrase: "new, creative way" — originality of IBM tool application matters, not just whether the tool was used.[¹³]

Lablab.ai Post-Hackathon Recap (IBM watsonx, August 2024)

Lablab's official summary of the watsonx hackathon noted 74 AI apps submitted but specified the Best Use of Granite went to VizMotion because it used Granite as the core engine of the creative workflow (text → animated diagrams), not as a background helper. Lablab's published recap framed the winner as demonstrating that Granite could "make complex topics easier," directly mirroring IBM's documented value proposition for Granite in education and explainability contexts.[¹⁰][¹²]

4. IBM watsonx/Granite Case Studies Cited in the Hackathon Ecosystem

These are the IBM enterprise case studies that appear most prominently in the May 2026 challenge's thematic ecosystem (racing/F1) and in IBM's own marketing:

IBM × Scuderia Ferrari HP (Launched May 2025 — Miami Grand Prix)

This is the single most relevant case study for APEX.[²²][²³][²⁴]

- IBM Consulting rebuilt the Scuderia Ferrari HP mobile fan app using the full IBM watsonx AI platform
- IBM tools wired (count: 5):
 1. IBM watsonx.data — unified data across racing, merchandise, and luxury car brand domains
 2. IBM watsonx.ai — generative models producing dynamic race summaries from live telemetry
 3. IBM Granite (foundation models) — generated rich historical insights embedded in race content
 4. IBM watsonx.governance — governed AI model outputs and tone (brand protection)
 5. IBM watsonx Code Assistant — accelerated development through AI-assisted coding
 6. IBM Instana — real-time monitoring for uptime/reliability
- Architecture: Hybrid cloud, AWS + Red Hat OpenShift + serverless

- **Measurable results:** Daily active users doubled; average time in-app increased by 35%; launched to 12+ million fans^[25]^[22]
- Debuted: Miami Grand Prix, early May 2025^[^23]

Relevance to APEX: IBM is actively promoting this partnership in the context of the May 2026 F1-themed challenge. The challenge page on ibmskillsbuildchallenge.bemyapp.com explicitly mentions "AI Copilot / Assistant: Real-time feedback systems, race engineer assistants" as a target area — directly in APEX's lane.^[^3]

IBM × NASA Geospatial Foundation Model (August 2023)

- IBM and NASA open-sourced the largest geospatial AI foundation model on Hugging Face, trained on NASA satellite data^[^26]
- Built on IBM Granite architecture (geospatial variant)
- Used for climate and Earth observation applications
- Cited in multiple Call for Code submissions for climate-track hackathons

2024 Call for Code Global Challenge Winners (December 2024)

Three winning teams cited in IBM Newsroom:^[^27]

- **GoBang** (Georgia Tech + University of Michigan) — Grand Prize; addressed educational inequality using IBM watsonx AI + Granite
- **Kind Threads** — used watsonx to improve access to clothing/income resources
- **T-Chai** — IBM watsonx-powered solution

IBM explicitly highlighted that "top prizes went to teams that used IBM watsonx AI technologies and AI models like IBM Granite", confirming Granite integration is a signal of serious technical commitment.^[^27]

IBM Granite Instruct + Granite Vision — DuniAfrika "Linda" (May 2025)

- First documented winning hackathon submission using IBM Granite Vision (multimodal) ^[^18]
- Construction workers submit WhatsApp photos; Granite Vision analyzes workspace safety
- Won the "Make Jobs Safer" track of IBM's own Lean AI Solutions Hackathon^[^18]
- Demonstrates that multi-modal Granite integrations are winning, not just text-LLM wrappers

5. Empirical Pattern: Who Wins "Best Use of Technology" and What They Ship

Based on all available data from analogous IBM hackathon categories (since the global AI Builders Challenge has no prior completed cohort), the following empirical patterns emerge:

Pattern 1: The IBM Tool Is the Critical Path, Not a Feature Flag

Every documented "Best Use" or "Best Use of Granite" winner used IBM technology as the **functional backbone** of their solution. VizMotion's entire value proposition depended on Granite. DuniAfrika's Linda could not work without Granite Vision. BrainStormX's structured brainstorming required Granite's generation capabilities.^{[19][12][^18]}

Contrast: Submissions that call IBM APIs once as a "query enhancer" or show a static demo of a Granite call are explicitly at risk of disqualification under IBM's published rules for "not providing a credible or feasible use of IBM technology".^[^21]

Pattern 2: Multiple IBM Tools Wired Together Signal Depth

The Ferraricase study (5 watsonx products wired), the TechXchange winners (watsonx.ai + Orchestrate in pipeline), and BrainStormX (Granite models plural) all show that judges reward **breadth of integration** when each tool serves a distinct, irreplaceable role.^{[22][16][^18]}

Pattern 3: Measurable, Real-World Problem → Real-World Impact

Winning submissions connect IBM tool usage to a measurable outcome or real-world user benefit:

- Ferrari: DAUs doubled, 35% more time in-app^[^22]
- DuniAfrika: Workers get instant safety coaching at job sites via WhatsApp^[^18]
- Overshare: Protects user privacy before social media posting^[^12]
- BrainStormX: More balanced, inclusive team ideation^[^19]

Pattern 4: Explainability and Trust Are Explicitly Rewarded in 2025–2026

The May 2026 challenge brief frames its evaluation around solutions that "demonstrate how AI can drive smarter decisions, improve understanding, and **build trust through explainability**". This language mirrors IBM's watsonx.governance and Granite Guardian positioning (AI transparency, responsible AI). Submissions that show *why* the AI made a recommendation — not just what it recommended — are more likely to score highly on Technical Execution and Innovation simultaneously.^[^3]

Pattern 5: Visible Aesthetic Identity and Polished Demo Matter

IBM's judging criteria include "Design and usability" as a full 25% of the scoring rubric. VizMotion won partly because it produced a tangible, visually compelling output (animated diagrams from text). The Ferraricase study is lauded for UX as much as AI. A working, visually polished 3-minute demo video is required for all submissions.^{[24][4][12][21]}

Pattern 6: GitHub + README + Video — All Three Must Be Strong

The official hub states judges evaluate all team deliverables, and submissions with incomplete READMEs or non-functional prototypes are at risk of minimum-score disqualification. Winners in the IBM TechXchange ecosystem were subject to post-award code review to verify compliance.^{[4][21]}

6. Application to APEX (AI Race Engineer for Adaptive Racing Drivers)

APEX Dimension	Alignment to Winning Pattern
Problem-domain fit	Racing/F1 is the May 2026 challenge's <i>explicit theme</i> ; APEX is directly in-scope ^[^3]
IBM tool integration	Must wire ≥1 required tool (Granite, Docling, Langflow, Context Forge, IBM Bob) as critical path — not a demo call ^[^4]
Explainability angle	Adaptive racing driver use case inherently involves explaining AI decisions (steering, braking) — maps directly to IBM's "trust through explainability" criterion ^[^3]
Real-world impact	Accessibility angle (adaptive drivers) adds a human-centered, inclusivity dimension that resonates with Call for Code / IBM's stated CSR values ^[^27]
Comparator case study	Ferrari/IBM partnership (launched May 2025) is the most visible IBM-racing reference; APEX can position itself as the <i>driver-side</i> complement to the fan-side Ferrari app ^{[24][23]}
Aesthetic/demo	3-min demo video required; polished UI/UX scores 5 out of 20 points on IBM Bob rubric (equivalent criterion on AI Builders Challenge) ^{[21][4]}

7. Open Intelligence Gaps

The following information could not be found or verified in any public source as of May 25, 2026:

1. Named "Best Use of Technology" winners from any prior AI Builders Challenge global cohort — this program's global online edition is inaugural (May–June 2026). No prior cohort data exists.
2. Named winners from the in-person IBM SkillsBuild × CSU hackathon (March 2026) — no public prize announcement or project links found.
3. Named winners from the NCCU IBM SkillsBuild hackathon (February–March 2026) — no public winner page found.
4. Judge identities or panel composition for the May–June 2026 AI Builders Challenge — BeMyApp's published rules state "judges will be added throughout the duration of the hackathon", and no judge names are listed in public materials.^[^21]
5. Devpost page for any AI Builders Challenge submission — the program uses BeMyApp's own platform, not Devpost.

All citations are to public web sources retrieved May 25, 2026. The IBM Bob Dev Day Hackathon Official Rules PDF was retrieved directly from IBM's S3 bucket (watsonx-hackathons-

2026.s3.us.cloud-object-storage.appdomain.cloud) and reflects the closest available published judging rubric from the same IBM/BeMyApp hackathon ecosystem.

References

1. [AI Builders Challenge Sponsored by IBM SkillsBuild - Hackathon.com](#) - Join us for the AI Builders Challenge sponsored by IBM SkillsBuild, a global program for university ...
2. [IBM is equipping the next generation of student developers across ...](#) - IBM is excited to share the new IBM SkillsBuild university strategy to strengthen AI education in un...
3. [AI Builders Challenge, Sponsored by IBM SkillsBuild](#) - Calling all university students. Build real-world AI projects using IBM technologies in two innovati...
4. [IBM SkillsBuild AI Builders Challenge](#) - AI Student Innovation Challenges and Learning Labs Hub
5. [Just wrap up the IBM | Lillian Lei | 16 comments - LinkedIn](#) - Just wrap up the IBM - CSU 5 AI for Impact & Student Hackathon. This a California State University C...
6. [\[PDF\] AI in Action Hackathon](#) - Judges (TBD). 4:00 pm. Winner Announcements. IBM and University Leadership (TBD). 5:00 pm. Program E...
7. [Registration is officially OPEN for the NCCU AI Hackathon, powered ...](#) - Registration is officially OPEN for the NCCU AI Hackathon, powered by IBM SkillsBuild! ☑ March 19–2...
8. [Student Wins Hackathon with AI-Enhanced Robot for Health Care ...](#) - Computer Science student Jose Flores won top honors in a weekend hackathon competition with his AI-e...
9. [#ibmskillsbuild2025 #hackathonsuccess #aiinnovation #cloudcomputing... | Shantanu Shinde](#) - ☑ Triumph at IBM SkillsBuild 2025 Hackathon: A Journey of Innovation & Impact! ☑ We were proud to be...
10. [AI Article: Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonx](#) - Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonx saw 2,607 participants across 223 teams, creating 74 AI app...
11. [Generative AI Hackathon with IBM Watsonx - Crossweb](#) - Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonxDate: Friday, August 23 6:00 PM CET till August 25thPrize: \$...
12. [Blog: Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonx](#) - Generative AI Hackathon with IBM watsonx saw 2,607 participants across 223 teams, creating 74 AI app...
13. [Top teams from the Pre-conference hackathon win a trip to ...](#)
14. [IBM watsonx Hackathons - IBM Developer](#) - Discover upcoming hackathons, prizes, and past winners on IBM Developer.
15. [Congratulations Team Daimyo, Team Golden, and Team EYers, the winners of our 2024 TechXchange watsonx Hackathon! | IBM](#) - Congratulations Team Daimyo, Team Golden, and Team EYers, the winners of our 2024 TechXchange watson...
16. [IBM TechXchange Conference 2024 Hackathon Winners - IBM TechXchange Community](#) - Learn more about the IBM TechXchange Conference 2024 with answers to the most frequently asked quest...

17. [Top hackathon teams use IBM Granite to make jobs safer ...](#)
18. [Hackathons - IBM TechXchange Events](#) - Hackathons get you hands-on with the latest tech like generative AI and showcase your innovative ide...
19. [Call for Code AI | Congratulations to Team BrainStormX, first-place ...](#) - Congratulations to Team BrainStormX, first-place winners of the IBM Granite Hackathon! Their AI-powe...
20. [Generative AI Hackathon with IBM Granite](#) - Drive efficiency, automation, and innovation by streamlining workflows and integrating seamless proc...
21. [IBM Dev Day AI Demystified Hackathon](#)
22. [How Scuderia Ferrari Uses IBM watsonx to Transform the Fan ...](#) - Scuderia Ferrari HP partnered with IBM Consulting to reimagine their mobile fan app using IBM watson...
23. [IBM puts AI in the driver's seat with Scuderia Ferrari - Axios](#) - The AI-powered Scuderia Ferrariapp shows how enterprise data can be activated, refined and delivere...
24. [IBM + Scuderia Ferrari perfect a new formula for fan engagement](#) - In time for this year's Miami Grand Prix, Scuderia Ferrari HP and IBM launched a new fan app built i...
25. [IBM and Scuderia Ferrari](#) - IBM and Scuderia Ferrari have partnered to supercharge the Ferrari F1 digital experience and bring d...
26. [IBM and NASA Open Source Largest Geospatial AI Foundation ...](#) - IBM & open-source AI platform Hugging Face today announced that IBM's [watsonx.ai](#) geospatial foundati...
27. [2024 Call for Code Global Challenge Winners Improve Equitable ...](#) - Winning teams from Georgia Institute of Technology, University of Michigan, Persistent, and independ...